

AUBABBLE



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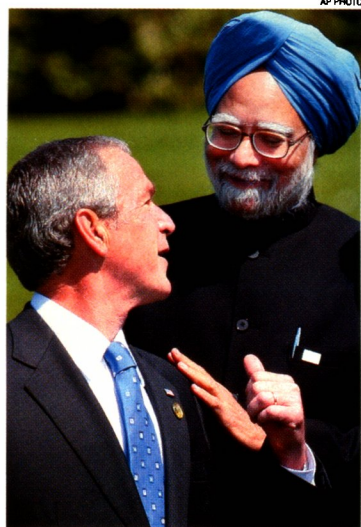
largest GHG emitters, including China and India, to agree on a new international framework by the end of 2008.

The US stance was dictated by the same reasoning it had applied when refusing to ratify the Kyoto Protocol that had set mandatory cuts in GHG emissions for developed countries. Washington had insisted then that unless India and China were also asked to make some commitments, the Protocol would be meaningless. At Heiligen-damm, President George W. Bush clearly adopted a "not on my watch" position towards suggestions for changes in America's policy. China and India contended that since the developed countries had caused the GHG emissions to rise to such dangerous levels, it was their responsibility to bring it down. In any case, as Manmohan pointed out, India's per capita GHG emissions was only 23 per cent of the

world average and 4 per cent of the US'. But to appear accommodative, Manmohan said India was willing to limit its GHG emission levels to that of industrialised countries. "It would act as an incentive for them to curb emissions to the lowest levels," he pointed out.

Finally, the compromise formula Merkel termed "a giant step forward" was that everyone's position was amalgamated towards working for a post-Kyoto treaty by 2009. (The Kyoto Protocol runs out by 2012.) A proposal by India and China to treat the UN as the forum for issues relating to global climate changes was accepted. The principle of "common but differentiated responsibility and respective capabilities between the developed and developing worlds" in any future agreements was once again endorsed by the industrialised nations. India and China saw no harm in having a dialogue as had been proposed by the US, provided any agreement would only be done under the UN framework. The US, on the other hand, promised to "seriously" consider the EU's proposals of mandatory GHG caps for industrialised countries post-Kyoto. Foreign Secretary Shivshankar Menon's assessment was "overall, India could come away feeling satisfied with the outcome".

For India, the summit also proved useful because Manmohan was able to have, what diplomats term, "pull aside" and "walk with" meetings with key G8 leaders. The most crucial of them was a brief chat with Bush. With the Indo-US nuclear deal running into major roadblocks over reprocessing rights and guaranteed supply of fuel for its civilian reactors, Manmohan spoke candidly about the problems. Bush listened attentively and took copious notes in long-hand which he handed over to his National Security Adviser Stephen Hadley. Manmohan thought the atmospherics of the meeting was "positive" and though "tough negotiations" lay ahead, the US President "felt a certain sense of ownership of the nuclear deal". The prime minister had other reasons to be satisfied: "Everyone at the G8 spoke highly of our growth rates and always mentioned China and India in the same breath." If the high growth rates continue, the hope is the G8 would be expanded to G10 to include the two nations. Any takers? ■



AP PHOTO

THEY AND US: Manmohan at the G8 Summit (top) and with Bush